Identity, Income, Accounts, Insurance, Property, Transfers: The Kinds of Records in an Application-Ready File and What to Keep of Each

Nineteen terms in one plain line each, and what to keep or write down.

Lists of what a Medicaid application may ask for use words nobody says at Dad's kitchen table: residency documents, transaction history, spousal information. These are the kinds of records an application-ready file holds, each with a plain line from a public source and a note on what to keep or write down.

The lines are for knowing what a word refers to. They aren't for working out what Dad's state requires or where he stands. A family can't settle that from a sheet, and isn't expected to.

The application, and who Dad is

Medicaid application

A form filled out for the state, plus documents that verify general and financial requirements. States run the program day to day and take the applications. [1]

WRITE DOWN Nothing yet; nobody is applying. Note the name of Dad's state Medicaid agency when you come across it.

Residency

Where a person lives. The federal Administration for Community Living lists being a resident of the state where a person applies among Medicaid's general requirements. [3]

WRITE DOWN Dad's legal residence, and where a paper showing it is kept.

Identity and status

Among the things a state Medicaid agency may ask for are a name and date of birth, a Social Security number, and proof of citizenship or immigration status. [2] [3]

WRITE DOWN Where Dad's birth certificate, Social Security card and any citizenship papers are kept.

Care and medical records

For long-term care services, a person's care needs are assessed as well as their finances. The federal long-term care glossary calls this functional eligibility. [4]

WRITE DOWN The names of Dad's doctors and where his health papers are kept. No assessing.

Income and what Dad has

Income

What comes in. The state counts some income but not all of it; the sources the federal Administration for Community Living lists include Social Security payments, veterans benefits, pensions, wages, interest and dividends. [3]

WRITE DOWN Each source, who pays it, and where its letter or statement is. Copy amounts as printed.

Investments

Accounts at a brokerage. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau lists bank and brokerage statements and account information among the documents most relevant to a person's finances. [6]

WRITE DOWN The firm, a contact name if there is one, and where the latest statement is.

Bank accounts

Checking, savings and credit union accounts. The National Institute on Aging's list of financial information to keep together includes the names of a person's banks and their accounts. [5]

WRITE DOWN The bank, the kind of account, the names printed on the statement, and whether statements come on paper or online.

Retirement accounts

A pension from an employer, IRAs and 401(k)s. The National Institute on Aging lists them among the sources of income and assets to keep information about. [5]

WRITE DOWN The plan or company, the kind of account, and where its statements are.

Insurance

Life, long-term care, home and car policies. The National Institute on Aging suggests keeping them together with policy numbers and agents' names and phone numbers. For long-term care insurance, Medicare.gov says to check the policy or call the company to find out what is covered. [5] [7]

WRITE DOWN The company, the kind of policy, the agent's name and where the policy itself is kept.

Real estate

For a home, a state may ask an applicant to document its current fair market value and any loans against it. A current tax bill, a real estate appraisal and copies of the mortgage are among the papers it may ask for. [1]

WRITE DOWN Where the deed, the latest tax bill and any mortgage or home equity loan papers are.

Other assets

Other things Dad owns, such as a vehicle with its title and registration. The federal long-term care glossary sorts assets into countable (value counted in determining financial eligibility for Medicaid) and exempt (value not counted). [4] [5]

WRITE DOWN What it is and where its title or paperwork is. Don't sort it into counted and not counted; that isn't the family's job.

The history

Transaction history

The record of money moving in and out over time, which statements show. If the value of a person's assets went down a lot in the years before applying, a state may ask what happened to them. [1]

WRITE DOWN For each larger event: what happened, the date, and what paperwork exists.

Gifts and transfers

A gift is something given away; a transfer moves money or property to someone else. The federal long-term care glossary defines “transfer of assets” as giving away property for less than it is worth or for the sole purpose of becoming eligible for Medicaid. [4]

WRITE DOWN What was given or moved, to whom, roughly when, and any paper that exists. No opinion on it; what it means is a question for your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney.

Special paperwork

Trust

A legal arrangement that allows a person to transfer assets, such as cash, property or insurance benefits, to another person, called the trustee. [8]

WRITE DOWN Whether Dad has one, its name and date, who the trustee is, and where the signed document is.

Annuity

A contract with an insurance company. [8]

WRITE DOWN The company, the contract's date, and where the contract and its statements are kept.

Spousal information

Medicaid has spousal impoverishment rules for married couples, and the glossary's word for the spouse of a nursing home resident applying for or receiving Medicaid long-term care services is “community spouse.” How the rules work is for a professional to explain. [3] [4]

WRITE DOWN If Dad is married: the same kinds of records for his spouse, and where the marriage certificate is.

Keeping it up

Statement retention

Keeping statements as they arrive. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau says to keep recent bank and brokerage statements available, along with information about how to get them online. [6]

WRITE DOWN Where statements are saved and who saves them. How far back to keep them is a question for your Medicaid planner.

Person responsible

A person may apply themselves or designate someone else, such as a family member, an attorney or a friend, who should be familiar with the situation and have access to the financial records. [1]

WRITE DOWN Who Dad would want, and whether that person knows where the file is.

Date of last update

When the file was last brought up to date. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau says to keep information as current as possible when something changes, such as a new account. [6]

WRITE DOWN The date at the top of the file, and who updated it.

What this sheet doesn't do

It names kinds of records. It doesn't say which ones Dad's state requires, how far back they need to go, or what any of them means for an application. Those answers come from your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know what each kind of record is and what to keep or write down about it. The planning interview goes on from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Applying for Medicaid
2. USA.gov, How to apply for Medicaid and CHIP
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid Eligibility
4. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Glossary
5. National Institute on Aging, Getting Your Affairs in Order Checklist: Documents to Prepare for the Future
6. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
7. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
8. National Institute on Aging, Paying for Long-Term Care